

Non-Service Animals on Campus Guideline

March 24, 2026

A. Purpose and Scope

This guideline does not apply to service animals or to animals housed in laboratory areas for academic or research purposes. For the Service Animal Guideline, please see [Service Animals Guideline – The Division of People Strategy, Equity & Culture \(utoronto.ca\)](#).

The University recognizes the importance to ensure the health and safety of our community while allowing the use of animals on campus that are essential for service of persons with disabilities or per the University's approved programs for academic or research purposes. The purpose of this guideline is to provide guidance on the presence of non-service animals, and it applies to all University of Toronto staff, faculty, students, contractors, and visitors while at University facilities to ensure a safe campus.

B. Definitions

The following definitions shall apply to this guideline:

- i. **Owner** refers to the legal owner of the animal. The owner may also be the handler.
- ii. **Handler** refers to the individual who has charge of the animal. The handler may also be the owner.
- iii. **University facility/facilities** refers to all buildings and grounds, owned, leased, or operated by the University of Toronto, including but not limited to outdoor areas, athletic and recreational fields, and residence and housing areas.
- iv. **Non-Service Animal (including pets)** refers to a domestic or tamed animal kept for companionship or pleasure that is not a service animal.

From time to time, University community members may wish to have animals (usually dogs) temporarily present on campus for various 'stress-relieving' events, such as Exam Jams. When organizing such events, planners should make every effort to seek out organizations that offer certified and vetted animals who are accompanied by vetted and trained handlers. Groups should also be mindful that the presence of animals might cause discomfort or anxiety for some community members. The same standards of behaviour outlined in the 'Behaviour and presence of service animals' section of the [Service Animal Guideline](#) also apply to such animals.

To discuss stress-relieving events involving animals, please contact the University's AODA Office directly at aoda@utoronto.ca or 416-978-7236.

- v. **Service animal** refers to an animal for a person with a disability as defined under Ontario Regulation 191/11: [Integrated Accessibility Standards](#) Part IV.2



subsection (4) under [Accessibility for Ontarians with Disabilities Act](#), 2005.

Service animals are permitted to accompany persons with disabilities and/or their handlers at the University unless prohibited by law (e.g. [in food preparation areas](#)) or the presence of the service animal endangers the health and safety of the community. If a service animal is required to be excluded from a space on campus, other arrangements will need to be explored in order to provide reasonable accommodations for the person with a disability, up to the point of undue hardship, so as to allow the person with a disability to obtain, use or benefit from the University's services and facilities. The AODA Office can assist with exploring other arrangements to accommodate the individual.

If you have any questions regarding whether a service animal may need to be excluded, please contact the University's AODA Office directly at aoda@utoronto.ca or 416-978-7236. For information regarding service animals, please see The Division of People Strategy, Equity and Culture on [Guidance regarding service animals on campus](#) or the [Student Life Animal Registration](#) webpage.

- vi. **Animals approved for academic or research purposes** at the University are permitted on campus for such purposes. For more information, please see Division of the Vice-President, Research & Innovation, [General Information about Animals in Research & Teaching](#).

C. Guideline on Non-Service Animal

1. The University of Toronto understands there may be extenuating circumstances which require specific considerations and exception which can be assessed on a case-by-case basis. Exceptions must be reviewed and approved by the Unit Head responsible for the area in writing. As an aid to inform the unit lead's decision, please refer to Appendix A for Non-Service Animal at Work Guidance.
2. The City of Toronto by-law prohibits certain animals to be used for private or public events, please see [Toronto Municipal Code Chapter 349 on Animals](#) for a list of prohibited animals at the University of Toronto.
3. This guideline does not supersede or replace obligations the University has under applicable legislations or by-laws, as well as contractual obligations for facilities leased or rented by the University.

D. Responsibility

Owners/Handler of Non-Service Animals

1. The owners/handler are to be respectful of the non-service animal and of other members of the community. Animals should not be permitted to impede normal movements of any person on campus nor be permitted to interfere with the ability of any student, faculty, staff, or other person who work or study on campus.
2. The owner/handler are to take full responsibility for any cost or consequences of



- damage caused by their non-service animal and to maintain physical control over the animal by not allowing the animal to be at large, remaining with their animal at all times, and cleaning up after their animal as applicable while at a University facility.
3. The owner/handler must ensure the animal does not jeopardize the health and safety of any member of the University, including other animals.
 4. The owner/handler must follow the provincial and local municipal laws related to ownership of animals including immunization, licensing, noise, large animals and dangerous animals under the [Dog Owners' Liability Act, R. S. O. 1990, c. D. 16](#).
 5. The owner/handler must comply with the [Health Protection and Promotion Act, R. S. O. 1990, c. H. 7](#), and the [Ontario Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, R. S. O. 1990, c. O. 36](#) to ensure appropriate animal care.

Staff and Faculty

1. In addition to the foregoing, staff and faculty require the explicit written consent of their supervisor/unit head prior to bringing a non-service animal to work during working hours. It is anticipated that consent would be given only in exceptional circumstances.

E. Contact

If you have any questions regarding non-service animals on campus, please contact us at 416-978-4467 or ehs.office@utoronto.ca.

F. Relevant Legislation

1. [Accessibility for Ontarians with Disabilities Act](#), 2005
2. [Blind Persons' Right Act](#), 1990
3. [Dog Owners' Liability Act, R. S. O. 1990, c. D. 16](#)
4. [Health Protection and Promotion Act, R. S. O. 1990, c. H. 7](#)
5. [Ontario Human Rights Code](#), 1990
6. Ontario Regulation 191/11: [Integrated Accessibility Standards](#)
7. [Ontario Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals Act, R. S. O. 1990, c. O. 36](#)
8. [Toronto Municipal Code Chapter 349, Animals](#)

G. Resources

1. The Division of People Strategy, Equity & Culture, [Guidance regarding Service Animal on Campus](#)
2. The Division of People Strategy, Equity & Culture, [Service Animals Guideline FAQ](#)
3. Council of Ontario Universities, [Animal on Campus Guide](#)



Appendix A: Non-Service Animal at Work Guidance

Please consider the following points prior to bringing a non-service animal to work:	
	Please be aware that not everyone is comfortable with animals being present. Animals may trigger allergies, negative experience, etc. Each person's rights should be carefully considered. Consider adding signage or a message to email tag lines to make others aware that an animal may be present.
	Ensure all members of the unit are made aware ahead of time when animals are going to be present. Have a mechanism to raise concerns.
	Persons bringing animals on campus will be held responsible for any costs or consequences of damage caused by their animal. Even the most docile of dogs could become hostile in an unfamiliar environment or around other pets.
	Animals can be a distraction. Designate a 'pet-friendly' day to ensure productivity is not affected.
	Establish animal-free zones – ground rules for where animals can roam free and where they should not be.
	Take turns or limit the number of animals each day, e.g. bring only one animal into the office at a time.
	Appoint a person to receive complaints / praise about program and the participants (animals). These comments would be taken back to the owner of the animal and/or Supervisor of the area.
	Ensure the office is safe for animals – cables, cords and open trash bins are tempting for animals.
	Vaccinations: Ensure animals are vaccinated as required by the local municipality (City of Toronto , Peel Region) and as recommended by their veterinarian.
	If your animal is sick, keep them at home. Sick animals spread germs. Ensure animals are healthy, flea/tick and heartworm treatments and well socialized.
	Animals must be supervised and leashed at all times.
	Animals must be comfortable around people (other than their owner).
	Animals must be okay around other animals.
	Animals who are hyper may not be appropriate in an office setting.
	Be prepared to bring everything the animal will need – toy, food, bed, etc.
	Clean up after your animal.